term with a great deal of respect, more as a term of endearment really), were unperturbed. Every morning before the physical training parade, they would yank out the offending withered saplings and replace them with small fresh twigs taken from the existing trees. This rigmarole used to continue for as long as I can remember but once again, I resolved that if and when my time came, I would not waste precious effort on such time-wasters.

Veena joined me in Binaguri and we had our first 'house' as a married couple, not counting the one- and two-room huts we had occupied from time to time. We did not have any luxuries, no fridge or TV, nothing except for a Bush two-in-one cassette player. No gas either and Veena had to cook on a kerosene stove. For someone who had grown up in metros, it was tough going and a big adjustment to make. We did have a pleasant interlude though, when the Battalion was sent temporarily to Darjeeling for internal security (IS) duties. Veena was carrying our first child, and it was glorious to sit in the sun, take long walks and sip on orange juice. Veena didn't stay long in Binaguri as the weather did not suit her, bringing on bouts of sneezing and asthma. Plus, the kerosene fumes were aggravating her morning sickness. For the better health of mother and child, Veena went back to stay with Rita (her mother) in Delhi. Our family time ended before it had even started, but as things turned out, it was for the best.

A short while after Veena had departed, I was sitting in the Adjutant's office adjoining the CO's office, when the head clerk walked in, saying that I had been shortlisted for a posting to 12 Corps, the raising of which was scheduled. This was a little unexpected, since Col Kapur had spoken to someone in the Military Secretary (MS) branch and had requested that since the unit had just moved to a new location, the team should remain unchanged for some time, and my posting, even if due,

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